If the query is executed on `text` fields, each individual result is returned with a relevancy score. The higher the score, the greater the relevancy (meaning the resultant document is a very close match). Results are sorted in descending order, with the result with the highest score at the top.

Not every result in a response is accurate. Just as we can expect an incorrect or irrelevant result sometimes when searching on Google, Elasticsearch may not return 100% relevant results. This is because Elasticsearch employs two internal strategies, precision and recall, that affect the relevancy of results.

Precision is the percentage of relevant documents retrieved over a set of documents available in the index, and *recall* is the percentage of relevant documents retrieved over a set of applicable (all relevant) documents. We discuss precision and recall in detail in chapter 10.

Many features are common to search regardless of the query type we choose (full-text, term-level, geospatial, etc.). We discuss these search features throughout the chapter and see applications of them in the next few chapters when we work with search and aggregations. The following section explains the mechanics of search: how Elasticsearch works on a search query to retrieve matching results.

8.2 How does search work?

A lot happens when a user invokes a search query against Elasticsearch. Although we touched on the mechanics earlier, let's recap. Figure 8.1 shows how the engine carries out a search in the background.

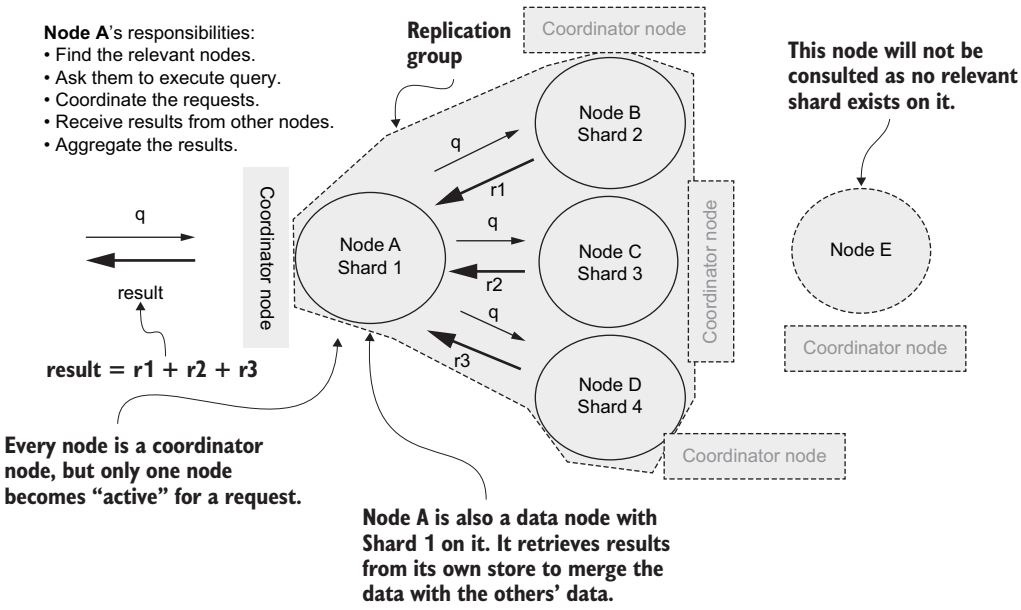


Figure 8.1 A typical search request, and the mechanics of how a search works